

# Can the Minimalist Approach of

# CDlinux



## Win You Over?

In the world of minimalist GNU/Linux distributions, we introduce you to CDlinux, which originated in the People's Republic of China, in 1999. Four years later, in 2003, the first public release, version 0.4.2, came out. The latest version 0.9.4, which was released on September 3, 2009, is a mere 67MB.

CDlinux, or Compact Distro Linux, was primarily intended for systems administrators, as a system rescue tool. However, it can also be used as a bare minimum portable desktop OS and as a customisable OS base. The default desktop environment is Xfce (currently 4.6.1) with the Thunar file manager, thus ensuring that CDlinux cuts out the fat. The whole distro loads on the RAM, so the access is rapid. The official edition's RAM requirement is only 64 MB. CDlinux is capable of booting from CD/DVD and HDD. It also supports USB and IEEE1394 interfaces.

According to the head developer, Ben Zhao: "The original purpose of CDlinux was for it to be used as an emergency/rescue tool for systems administrators. But thanks

to the versatility of Linux, it can also be customised for other types of users. It was used in schools by the Yellow Sheep River project ([yellowsheepriver.com](http://yellowsheepriver.com)) several years ago, and now I am helping the Beijing International School ([biss.com.cn](http://biss.com.cn)) to set up a version for kids. I have also helped others set up CDlinux for applications like a firewall, NAS, etc."

Currently, there are two core developers of CDlinux, Ben Zhao and Penta Cai. I discovered CDlinux as an unmaintained and 'dead' distro in [linux.org](http://linux.org). But when I visited the official website, I came to know that though it was not very popular, it certainly wasn't 'dead' and is still being developed. After using the 0.6.2 version of CDlinux, which was about 57.2 MB in size, I was impressed. Far from being dead,